

Chapter 04: How Childhood and Adolescence Affect Old Age

Brief Summary

This chapter asks how childhood shapes old age. Vaillant avoids the simple claim that bad childhoods doom people or that good childhoods guarantee success. Instead, he argues that what goes right in childhood predicts later well-being more powerfully than many single things that go wrong. The central variable is not wealth, discipline style, birth order, or even one isolated parental failure, but the total warmth of the early relational environment and the child's later ability to receive and give love.

Key Study Findings

- Childhood environment was rated using five domains: warm and stable home atmosphere, warm father relationship, warm mother relationship, encouragement of autonomy, and closeness to siblings.
- The warmest childhoods were called Cherished; the bleakest were called Loveless. These groups differed strongly in later relationships, mental health, and life satisfaction.
- By later life, the Loveless were eight times as likely as the Cherished to have experienced major depression.
- The Cherished were four times as likely as the Loveless to enjoy warm social supports at seventy.
- The men with the warmest childhoods made roughly 50 percent more money than the men with the bleakest childhoods, but parental social class itself was not the main explanation.
- Warm childhood was strongly associated with life satisfaction and late-life contentment. Closeness to father was especially associated with play, humor, retirement adjustment, and subjective satisfaction.
- Warm mother relationships were associated with work effectiveness, income, class rank, and a surprising lower rate of dementia by age ninety.
- Many assumed childhood predictors did not hold up well: strict discipline, breast-feeding, toilet training, birth order, childhood physical health, and even early parental death were less important than expected.
- Vaillant stresses the whole family climate. A single cold parent was less damaging than a globally disturbed childhood that undermined trust.

Interesting Stories And Examples

- Oliver Holmes illustrates the Cherished life. His parents were affectionate, principled, and autonomy-supporting. Their warmth was visible later in his marriage, parenting, work, and generous old age.
- Sam Lovelace illustrates the Loveless life. He was cared for materially but not emotionally, grew lonely and anxious, struggled with friendship and marriage, and spent much of life unable to trust love when it appeared.
- Lovelace's late-life improvement matters. After widowhood and through civic service, medication, and later relationships, he becomes less depressed and more connected, showing that bad childhoods are costly but not always final.
- Camille's recovery of a tender memory of his father under a cherry tree shows Vaillant's idea of lost loves: old remembered affection can become a late source of healing.

Why It Matters

The chapter's practical lesson is hopeful but not naive. Early warmth is protective, early lovelessness is painful, and the deepest injury is often the later inability to love and be loved.